

Emmet in VS Code

A practical HTML shortcut guide for writing structure faster.



Built into Visual Studio Code · Expand abbreviations instantly with Enter or Tab

Keyboard shortcuts calibrated for standard VS Code installs on Windows, macOS, and Linux.

CORE WORKFLOW

Start with the essentials

Type an abbreviation, then press Enter or Tab to expand it directly into formatted HTML.

Abbreviation	Expands to	Typical use case
!	<!DOCTYPE html>...	Generates a full HTML5 document skeleton
div		Generic layout block
p		Text paragraph
h1		Primary page heading
a		Hyperlink with cursor placed inside href
img		Image tag with src and required alt attribute
button	<button></button>	Interactive form or UI button

SKELETON SHORTCUT



The exclamation mark expands into `head`, `meta charset`, `viewport`, and `body` tags in one stroke, giving you an immediate starting point for new files.

Tip: If Emmet suggestions do not appear automatically, press Ctrl + Space to trigger autocomplete.

SYNTAX RULES

Build structure with classes, IDs, and operators

Combine CSS selectors and algebraic operators to generate nested hierarchies without typing closing tags.

SELECTORS

`.box`

Creates `<div class="box"></div>`. Tag defaults to `div` when omitted.

`#header`

Creates `<div id="header"></div>` with an ID attribute.



Text content `{text}`

Adds literal text inside tags: `a{Click here}` produces `<a href="">Click here</a>`.



Auto numbering `$`

Replaced by an incrementing counter when used alongside repetition operators.

HIERARCHY OPERATORS

`>` (Child operator)

Places the right-hand element inside the left: `div>p`.

`+` (Sibling operator)

Places elements next to each other on the same level: `h1+p`.



Custom attributes `[attr]`

Sets element attributes: `td[colspan=2]` expands with the specified attribute set.



Grouping `()`

Groups subtrees together so sibling and parent chains evaluate predictably.

Operators can be combined infinitely: `header>(nav>ul>li*3>a)+button`.

REPETITION & DYNAMIC CONTENT

Generate lists, text, and repeated components

Multiply identical or sequenced items using the asterisk operator and dollar-sign variable counters.

Expression	Output structure	Purpose
<code>ul>li*5</code>	Unordered list containing 5 <code></code> items	Standard navigation or bulleted list stub
<code>ol>li*5</code>	Ordered list containing 5 <code></code> items	Numbered step sequence or instructions
<code>p{Item \$}*5</code>	5 paragraphs: <code>Item 1</code> through <code>Item 5</code>	Repeated text with automatic numerical indices
<code>li.item\$*5</code>	5 list items with classes <code>item1</code> to <code>item5</code>	Sequenced CSS classes for styling hooks

MULTIPLIER SYNTAX



Repeat any tag or grouped block N times

Numbering formats

Use a single `$` for plain numbers (1, 2, 3). Use double dollars `$$` for leading zeroes (01, 02, 03) when building padded IDs, pagination tracks, or numbered asset references.

Example: `ul>li.chapter-$$*3>a{Section $}` generates three links with zero-padded classes and natural text numbers.

FORMS & LANDMARKS

Speed up forms and semantic HTML

Input type shortcuts and landmark tags replace verbose configuration with short, descriptive tokens.

INPUT TYPE ABBREVIATIONS

Shortcut	Generated input tag
input:email	<input type="email">
input:password	<input type="password">
input:number	<input type="number">
input:checkbox	<input type="checkbox">
input:date	<input type="date">
input:search	<input type="search">

SEMANTIC STRUCTURAL TAGS

Tag	Semantic role
header	Introductory banners or page headers
nav	Major navigation link groups
main	Central unique content of the page
section	Thematic grouping of document content
article	Self-contained syndicated content
aside	Secondary sidebars or callouts
footer	Colophon, copyright, or footer links

Semantic tags require no special syntax: type the tag name alone and press Enter to expand clean, accessible landmarks.

READY-TO-USE BLUEPRINTS

Use patterns you'll meet in real projects

Common UI components can be scaffolded entirely from a single composed Emmet line.



Navigation menu

```
nav>ul>li*4>a
```

Builds a semantic navigation bar with four list items and link anchors ready for hrefs.



Content card

```
div.card>img+h2+p+button
```

Generates an image thumbnail, title heading, descriptive paragraph, and action button inside a styled container.



Login form

```
form>label+input:email+label+input:password+button
```

Produces paired labels and specialized inputs with a submission button.



Image with caption

```
figure>img+figcaption
```

Accessible graphic block pairing a photo tag with its semantic text caption.



Search box

```
div.search>input:search+button
```

Compact search input with quick submit button wrapped in a styling division.

Pro tip: Tab through generated elements to jump between cursor stops inside attributes and tag bodies.

EDITOR ACCELERATION

Pair Emmet with high-value VS Code shortcuts

Combine structural generation with native editor commands for fast multi-line authoring and refactoring.

Code editing

Ctrl + /

Toggle line comment on or off

Shift + Alt + F

Format entire active document

Shift + Alt + ↑/↓

Duplicate current line up or down

Alt + ↑/↓

Move current line or selection up/down

Search & Replace

Ctrl + F

Find text in the open file

Ctrl + H

Find and replace matches

Ctrl + S

Save file changes

Multi-cursor & Selection

Ctrl + D

Select next occurrence of matching word

Ctrl + Shift + L

Select all occurrences across the file

Ctrl + Space

Force trigger suggestion and Emmet popup

History & State

Ctrl + Z

Undo the last edit or expansion

Ctrl + Y

Redo the last undone action

MACOS USERS

Substitute **Cmd** for Ctrl and **Option** for Alt across all commands.

Power move: Combine Emmet expansion with **Ctrl + D** to rapidly rename mirrored classes or attributes across siblings.

Practice by expanding from small to complex

01 Start with a single element such as `p` or `div.box`.

02 Combine children and siblings, such as `header>nav+main`.

03 Add repetition, numbering, text, and attributes as the structure becomes more specific.

04 Use the real-world patterns as reusable starting points, then replace placeholder text and attributes.